ADIYA KARSYBEK

Environmental & Urban Planning Specialist | Climate Resilience, Nature-based Solutions & Sustainable Development in Central Asia

Astana, Kazakhstan • +7 702 980 0870 • adiyakarsybek@gmail.com • linkedin.com/in/adiya-karsybek-urbanist

PROFESSIONAL PROFILE

Environmental and urban planning specialist with 9+ years' experience delivering climate adaptation, resilience and sustainable-development initiatives across Central Asia, including with the United Nations and EU-funded programmes. Proven record of coordinating multi-stakeholder projects, embedding disaster risk reduction (DRR) and nature-based approaches into public policy and municipal planning, and building partnerships across government, civil society, academia and international organisations. Combines applied field experience in Kazakhstan with a distinction-level Master of Planning from The Bartlett, UCL (London). Recognised for interdisciplinary leadership, participatory and community-led methods, and evidence-based decision-making. Fluent in English and Russian with working Kazakh, and committed to advancing environmental governance and ecosystem-based development across the Central Asian region.

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

- Programme & Portfolio Coordination
- Nature-based Solutions & Green Infrastructure
- Stakeholder Engagement & Partnership-building
- Team & Line Management
- Strategic & Spatial Planning
- Monitoring, Evaluation & Reporting
- Climate Adaptation & Disaster Risk Reduction
- Environmental & Urban Governance
- Participatory & Community-led Design
- Evidence-based Decision-making & Research
- Policy & Standards Development
- International Cooperation & Capacity-building

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

National Consultant — Urban Planning & Climate Resilience
Jul 2025 – Present

United Nations Development Programme (UNDP)
Astana / Petropavlovsk, Kazakhstan

- Developed a concept note and funding application for an urban climate-resilience project, UNDP Kazakhstan.
- Lead the technical adaptation of a UNDP climate-change and **disaster risk reduction (DRR) methodology** into municipal planning for Petropavlovsk, a city exposed to annual Esil River flooding — strengthening urban resilience to climate-related hazards.
- Author the **Concept for Petropavlovsk's Master Plan**, embedding climate adaptation, DRR and resilience measures into long-term municipal strategy and decision-making.
- Coordinate delivery between **local government, UNDP and international technical experts**, aligning strategies and ensuring effective knowledge transfer across institutions.
- Line-manage a team of two planners, overseeing planning, quality assurance and delivery against project objectives.

Focus: *Climate adaptation & DRR integration · environmental governance · inter-institutional coordination · international cooperation*

Manager — Landscape Master Plan Product Development
Jun 2025 – Jan 2026

BI Group (BI Development)
Astana, Kazakhstan

- Established and led a new corporate unit responsible for **landscape and green-infrastructure master planning** across residential and mixed-use developments at Kazakhstan's largest developer.
- Redeveloped corporate landscape standards and regulations, aligning them with **sustainability goals and international best practice** through structured research and gap analysis.
- Designed and launched a resident-participation survey to ground landscape planning in community needs; completed the first data-collection phase.
- Supervised landscape designers and drove the digitalisation of design standards (incl. Revit).

Focus: *Urban ecosystems & green infrastructure · sustainability standards · evidence-based planning · participatory research*

Research Assistant — 'Converted Homes' Study
May 2024 – Dec 2024

UCL, The Bartlett School of Planning
London, United Kingdom

- Conducted primary qualitative research (Prof Ben Clifford & Prof Helen Pineo) examining the health, well-being and **climate-related impacts** of permitted-development housing across England.
- Delivered semi-structured interviews, systematic site observation and standardised home assessments under rigorous **ethical research protocols**.

Focus: *Applied research · qualitative data collection · evidence generation · research ethics*

Planning & Urban Design Intern (Master's placement)
Jan 2024 – Mar 2024

Dar Al-Handasah
London, United Kingdom

- Conducted international **benchmarking research on Transit-Oriented Development and Industrial Symbiosis** to inform master plans across EMEA, Europe and the Americas.
- Produced client-facing analytical diagrams and visual communications (InDesign, Illustrator, Photoshop, AutoCAD).

Focus: *Comparative research · sustainable & circular-economy planning · analytical communication*

Lead Urban Planner & Co-founder
Jan 2021 – present

Q88 Association for Sustainable Territorial Development
Astana, Kazakhstan

- Co-founded and led a non-profit professional network for sustainable territorial development, **growing membership from 15 to 50+ within one year** and managing a core team of three.
- Managed **UNICEF-funded projects across the full cycle (50K $) — from proposal to delivery** — designing inclusive playground prototypes for children with disabilities and chronic illness, culminating in a national handbook and a multi-stakeholder online forum presented with UNICEF.
- Developed urban development master plans for Atyrau and Pavlodar and facilitated **participatory co-design events** with residents, professional bodies and public institutions.
- Adapted national planning instruments (Catalogue 4, Kazakhstan Urban Development Standards).

Focus: *Donor-funded project cycle management · partnership-building · capacity-building · standards & policy development*

Senior Urban Planner / Designer
Mar 2020 – Dec 2020

Turkistan City Lab
Turkistan, Kazakhstan

- Led seven urban design projects in a growing cultural and religious centre, integrating **nature-based solutions — green infrastructure and water-management measures** — into public-space design.
- Applied participatory design to include under-represented groups (women, children and people with disabilities).
- Managed a team of three; delivered public realm around the **Khoja Ahmed Yasawi Mausoleum (UNESCO World Heritage Site)**.

Focus: *Nature-based solutions · green & blue infrastructure · inclusive participatory design*

Manager — Transport Infrastructure Development
Jun 2019 – Feb 2020

AlmatyElectroTrans
Almaty, Kazakhstan

- Coordinated implementation of the **Vision Zero** road-safety programme; led the redesign of seven streets with safer layouts and public- and active-transport priority.
- Contributed to a **reduction in traffic fatalities from 71 to 25** through integrated design and monitoring measures, managing a team of four specialists.
- Led internal qualitative research on organisational reform; presented evidence-based recommendations to the company board and city authorities.

Focus: *Sustainable mobility · monitoring & evaluation · team leadership · measurable impact*

Senior Architect – Urbanist
Sep 2016 – Jun 2019

Almaty Urban Studies / Development Centre
Almaty, Kazakhstan

- Helped establish Kazakhstan's **first Urban Studies Centre** as a bridge between citizens and government through co-design and co-governance; delivered 20+ projects and organised 100+ public-engagement events.
- Established and delivered the **EU-funded 'WeAlmaty' active-citizenship project (400k $)** in partnership with the British Council, Kazakh-British Technical University and Almaty municipality.
- Collaborated with **Gehl Architects** on the Golden Square regeneration and contributed to Almaty's first 10 km BRT corridor.

Focus: *EU-donor engagement · environmental & urban governance · international partnerships · public engagement*

EDUCATION

Master of Planning — Distinction
2022 – 2024

University College London (UCL), The Bartlett School of Planning
London, United Kingdom

- RTPI- and RICS-accredited City Planning programme, funded by the Government of Kazakhstan **'Bolashak' Scholarship**.
- Dissertation on women's leadership and gender-inclusive decision-making in Kazakh planning — graded **High Distinction** and awarded the **Pumarino-Orbeta Prize for Best Dissertation**; shortlisted for the RTPI Research Excellence Award.

Bachelor of Arts in Architecture
2011 – 2016

Satbayev University
Almaty, Kazakhstan

- Five-year professional programme (GPA 3.41); specialised in urban design, car-free centres and biophilic, pedestrian-first planning.

Exchange Programme in Architecture & Urban Design
2015 – 2016

Bialystok University of Technology (Politechnika Białostocka)
Białystok, Poland

LEADERSHIP, NETWORKS & PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT

- **Founder — Ayel & Qala**, a professional network advancing women's leadership in urban development across Kazakhstan and Central Asia.
- **Co-founder — Q88: Association for Sustainable Territorial Development**; and of the Expert Community of Urban Planners and Developers (Kazakhstan Housing Company).
- **Mentee —** Commonwealth Association of Planners (CAP) 'Headway' and 'Women in Planning' international mentorship programmes.
- **Guest lecturer & speaker —** 'Post-Socialist Cities' (UCL); 'Women & Planning: From Theory to Practice' (Leeds, 2024), City Transformation Intensive (2025 – currently)

AWARDS & RECOGNITION

- **Pumarino-Orbeta Prize** — Best Master's Dissertation, The Bartlett, UCL (2023/24).
- **Steppe Award** for creative industries, 'Urban Studies' category.
- **RTPI Research Excellence Award** — shortlisted finalist (Student Dissertation).
- **Letters of appreciation** from the Mayor of Almaty, the Almaty Development Centre, and the Minister of Industry & Infrastructure Development of Kazakhstan.

LANGUAGES & TECHNICAL SKILLS

Languages: English (fluent, professional) • Russian (native) • Kazakh (intermediate, B1)

Technical: Qualitative research & interviewing • spatial & GIS-oriented analysis • AutoCAD, Revit, SketchUp • Adobe Creative Cloud (InDesign, Illustrator, Photoshop) • data visualisation & reporting

REFERENCES

Available on request. Referees include:

Ara Nazinyan — International Supervisor & Expert in Resilient Cities and DRR, UNDP (Petropavlovsk Project)
Dr Susan Moore — Dissertation Supervisor & Module Tutor, The Bartlett, UCL
Dr Michael Short — Director, MSc City Planning, The Bartlett, UCL
Sean Kelly — Mentor, Commonwealth Association of Planners 'Headway' Programme